Social Media Clones: Exploring the Impact of Social Delegation with AI Clones through a Design Workbook Study

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Social media clones are AI-powered social delegates of ourselves created using our personal data. As our identities and online personas intertwine, these technologies have the potential to greatly enhance our social media experience. If mismanaged however, these clones may also pose new risks to our social reputation and online relationships. To set the foundation for a productive and responsible integration, we set out to understand how social media clones will impact our online behavior and interactions. We conducted a series of semi-structured interviews introducing eight speculative clone concepts to 32 social media users through a design workbook. Applying existing work in AI-mediated communication in the context of social media, we found that although clones can offer convenience and comfort, they can also threaten the user's authenticity and increase distrust within the online community. As a result users tend to behave more like their clones to mitigate discrepancies and interaction breakdowns. These findings are discussed through the lens of past literature in identity and impression management to highlight challenges in the adoption of social media clones by the general public, and propose design considerations for their successful integration into social media platforms.

CCS Concepts: • **Human-centered computing** → **Social media**; **Empirical studies in HCI**; • **Computing methodologies** → *Philosophical/theoretical foundations of artificial intelligence.*

Additional Key Words and Phrases: AI Clones, Social Network Sites, Identity, Interpersonal Relationship, Impression Management, Context Collapse, AI Agents, Machine Learning Applications, Human-AI Interaction, AI-mediated Communication

ACM Reference Format:
Jackie Liu, Mehrnoosh Shirvani, Hwajung Hong, Ig-Jae Kim, and Dongwook Yoon. 2026. Social Media Clones: Exploring the Impact of Social Delegation with AI Clones through a Design Workbook Study. *Proc. ACM Hum.-Comput. Interact.* 10, 2, Article CSCW036 (April 2026), 31 pages. https://doi.org/10.1145/3788072

1 Introduction

The idea of leveraging generative AI and personal data to represent one's self, or AI clones, has become a reality within social media. In May 2023, LinkedIn introduced their new AI-assisted messaging feature [81], enabling recruiters to create personalized reach-out messages to potential candidates with a click of a button. Meta then took it a step further in September that same year by unveiling a series of interactive AIs to their social media platforms [62]; taking on celebrity

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ACM 2573-0142/2026/4-ARTCSCW036
https://doi.org/10.1145/3788072

personas like Tom Brady and Snoop Dogg, these AIs were met with a great deal of curiosity and criticism due to their replication of real life individuals. These early integrations, though varying in success, highlight the need for a deeper understanding of how AI clones may shape our social media experiences, both positively and negatively.

While clones can exist through many modalities including visual deepfakes [5] or voice mimicry [71], the predominance of text-based communication on social media makes text-based clones the focus of our study. Concerns surrounding clones and the challenges they present to users have been explored by past studies. Lee et al. introduced issues such as doppelgänger-phobia and identity fragmentation [55], demonstrating the clones' potential to exploit our online identity and threaten our self perception. Morris et al. explained how clones can damage the user's reputation by creating negative perceptions of them [64]. For risks to relationships in particular, Jakesch et al. has shown that undisclosed AI use can decrease trust and cause tension within communication [42]. These studies emphasize the importance of designing responsible clones in order to mitigate their risk to our security, self identity, and personal relationships.

Despite these challenges, AI clones hold promise for enhancing online interactions, including communication facilitation [17, 36, 89, 96] and supporting conflict resolution [35], all while offering even greater personalization than existing AI-mediated communication technologies. Within social media, we are witnessing a rapid increase of both platform- and user-generated clones [30, 78, 86, 93], making these platforms a highly accessible and direct entry point for the general public to engage with such technologies. This growing prevalence of clones underscores the importance of gaining a thorough understanding of how to maximize the benefits of AI clones while mitigating their potential risks.

The application of AI clones holds particular significance within social media, as the clones by their very nature challenge and reshape our identities—an element at the core of social interactions [83]. Our study draws on the communication theory of identity, which describes the multilayered nature of identity [31], and how inter-layer tension can negatively impact communication [43, 94]. Extending this concept of identity into the context of social media, we can view our online identity as a more explicit expression of our four identity layers, therefor inheriting the characteristics of inter-layer tension and negotiation. For many of us, these social platforms have become a valuable source of emotional connection [13, 18], and any issues that arise can significantly impact our social reputations and relationships [7]. Expanding on previous work to unveil the unique effects clones would have within social media will be crucial for their successful integration.

As a result, this study sets out to answer the research question, *What are the benefits and risks of AI clones in social media, along with their ramifications on its users?* Our exploration of AI clones is framed through the lens of past literature in the following domain:

1) Social Media Practices [90]: How will AI clones be adopted into peoples' online presentations and what are the value and risks they create for user agency, self-identity and impression management? Impression management has been shown to be a complex process on social media due to the challenges of balancing authenticity with the ideal presentation of oneself [60, 91, 102]. The use of these clones may also affect the delicate balance of user- and AI agency on social media, which requires nuanced negotiation to operate effectively [48]. Understanding how users adapt their social media practices to the introduction of clones may provide insight into how we can preserve the agency and identity of social media users.

2) AI-mediated Communication [28]: Within social interactions involving clones, what are factors that determine impression transfer, and their effects on relationship formation and maintenance? Explicit AI-mediated communication has shown both potential for maintaining relationships [35] as well as undermining interpersonal perceptions [63]. The possibility of impression transfer from AI to humans has also been observed [56], along with an increase in mistrust, known as the "Replicant

Effect," when the use of AI is not disclosed [42]. These effects may be exacerbated in the case of clones, as personal identity is further manipulated and communication may become entirely with the clone itself. All these factors may have a profound impact on our long term relationship development online, which often values trustfulness and equality [21].

To address the speculative nature of AI clones in the social media context, we developed a design workbook featuring eight distinct concepts of clone use in social media. The design workbook was presented to 32 active social media (i.e., Facebook, X, LinkedIn) users in a series of interviews. Through these interviews, we captured their responses to a range of scenarios involving clones. Results from the study revealed both the value clones can bring to productivity and comfort, the risks they pose to the authenticity of social media, and the consequences of those risks on the Target's impression and relationships.

This study contributes empirical findings on the benefits and risks of text-based clones on our social reputation and relationships, alongside the impact these clones can have on people's impression management practices and impression transfer mechanisms. Furthermore, it extends relevant theories by empirically demonstrating the nuanced ways impression management, identity negotiation, and relationship dynamics operate when mediated by AI clones in social media.

2 Related Work

This work builds on prior research concerning definitions of AI-based human representations, the dynamics of user versus AI agency, theories of identity and impression management, and the impact of AI on trust in social interactions.

2.1 Defining Social Media Clones

AI-based digital representation of humans has become commonplace on social media [49, 97]. Technologies like deepfakes that uses AI to mimic the voice and visual likeness of a person [5] have caused a fair share of controversy in the online community due to their frequent misuse [65, 68]. Going beyond the physical aspects of an individual, AI also has the potential to learn and predict our behavior. Truby and Brown [88] expanded on this concept in the context of marketing and defined what they call a "Human digital thought clone", where each individual consumer will have a "digital twin" that is created from all the available data of that specific person. They referred to this as the "Holy Grail" for advertisers as it is akin to having access to each consumer's thoughts, giving companies even greater power to predict and influence consumer decisions. Text-based AI clones more closely algin with the latter example, where they replicate aspects of a person's identity and social presence in ways that extend beyond surface-level appearance.

Although cloning consumer behavior has become a prominent use case due to its commercial value, it is far from the only application that this technology has to offer. Saddik [19] described another concept of a "digital twin", which can improve an individual's quality of life and enhance well-being by modeling their health and predict illness. McIlroy-Young et al. [61] proposed AI models of individuals that are designed for interaction. These researchers coined the term "Mimetic Models", which describes an algorithm trained with data from an individual in a specific domain, with the goal of simulating their behavior in new situations within that domain. Lee et al. [55] had a similar definition, where AI clones are described as interactive agents that represent some aspects of a specific person, built on the personal data of that person.

Finally, we shall refer to AI clones that exist within a social media platform as *Social Media Clones*, defined by the following representative features:

(i) *Each social media clone is built on the data of a Target using artificial intelligence.*
(ii) *Social media clones are generative, responding to external input as the Target would.*
(iii) *Social media clones are interactive through the affordances of the platform they reside in.*

This definition closely aligns with our design concepts, adapted from a combination of the definitions proposed by prior work [55, 61], with some modifications to ground it in the domain of social media. What makes these clones unique is their integration with social media affordances [15]. This includes both high level affordances like self-expression and persistence [1, 87], as well as feature specific affordances like the ability to direct message people or publish posts on a timeline [20].

2.2 User Agency vs. AI Agency in Social Media

AI is a prominent component of many modern social media platforms. When used behind the scenes they can enhance platform affordances such as personalization in content consumption [73, 80] and online networking [74]. They can also be used directly by the users as a tool for content creation and social engagement [11, 81]. As previously mentioned, Companies like Meta have begun experimenting with AI chatbots for users to talk to. Similarly, Snapchat came up with a feature they call "My AI", which is a personal chatbot that is unique to each individual, and can be personalized based on the user data it receives [40]. Numerous third party tools have also emerged that help users improve their online image through services like writing their profile bios or generating their profile pictures [11].

However, this increasing involvement of AI in social media may challenge the agency of its users [48], an important aspect for those who value greater autonomy [12]. Kang and Lou explained how negotiating user agency and AI agency plays a critical role in social media engagement [48]. Their research highlights how the two agencies can find synergy through mutual augmentation, where the user strikes a balance between exerting their own agency versus allowing the AI to provide a more convenient or enjoyable social media experience. Cheng et al. describes a similar trade-off betweem control and delegation in their study comparing shared-autonomy versus fully autonomous AI conversational agents [17]. Balancing this trade-off is particularly relevant with AI clones, as users must find the appropriate amount of agency they are willing to give up for the proper operation of their clones.

2.3 Identity and Impression Management

Many theories of identity have emerged in psychology and sociology. Our study primarily focus on Hecht and Phillips' communication theory of identity (CTI) [31], which conceptualizes identity as the summation of 4 interdependent layers: *personal* – how an individual views themselves. Within social media, this can be reflected in user profiles, bios, and the decision making process of sharing content online. *relational* – who an individual is in relation to others. This can be observed when users behave differently when talking to different people, such as in group chats of different friend groups or direct messages. *enacted* – how an individual expresses themselves through actions. This can be categorized by all the posts, comments, likes, etc. a user performs through the social media features. Finally, *communal* – how an individual is defined within a group. This is expressed by the groups or communities a user is a part of. Even the different platforms themselves can reflect communal identity as they may each have their own social norms and behavioral expectations. An identity gap may occur when there are inconsistencies between two or more identity layers, prompting us to correct one of the layers through our actions or thought process in order to avoid negative communication or relational outcomes [43, 94]. Adopting a social identity perspective allows us to rationalize the self-presentation and intra-group interactions of AI clone users [77]. Through the lens of CTI, clones can be viewed as an extension of the Target's enacted identity. We can then understand how behavioral mismatches between the clone, and the Target's personal and relational identity can influence their behavior, and by extension their broader sense of self.

The idea of our identity being something malleable and expressed through our communication also plays a role in how we present ourselves to others. Goffman called this process impression management [26], which is how we influence other people's perception of us through social interactions. This is especially prevalent on social media platforms, where we have greater control over our self-presentation [95], and the ability to broadcast to our entire social network [60, 91, 102]. In the context of AI-mediated communication, impressions have been found to transfer from the AI onto the user [56]. To avoid being perceived negatively, Endacott and Leonardi [22] discovered how users managed their impressions in AI-MC through: 1. managing how their Interactors interpreted their use of clones (interpretation); 2. managing the relationship between Interactor and AI (diplomacy); and 3. monitored how they communicated with the AI when visible to Interactors (staging politeness). In turn, Interactors had three processes to form impressions of the Target: 1. AI reinforcing existing Target impressions (confirmation); 2. impression of the AI shaping the impression of the Target (transference); 3. viewing the impression of AI separate from the Target (compartmentalization). These processes provide valuable insight into how clones may affect the impression management and transference of Targets and help contextualize participant behavior within our study.

2.4 The Effects of AI on Trust in Social Interactions

The lack of trust in AI systems can have a negative impact on social interactions [36, 41]. Previous research observed what Jakesch et al. dubbed the "replicant effect", where people had higher mistrust of Airbnb profiles that they perceived to be AI generated [42]. Liu et al. found a similar effect where participants lowered their trust in email writers when it was revealed to them that an AI was involved in the writing process [58]. To increase trust in AI, studies have shown that large language models can explain their decisions to give users more context [38], creating a human-in-the-loop system that promotes transparency [57]. We can also improve confidence in these systems by increasing the user's data agency, giving them the ability to take actions on how their data is being collected and what it will be used for [4, 70].

Although our study focuses on text-based AI clones, previous work have looked at using AI agents to represent people in social interactions in the form of generative speech [39]. Hwang et al. suggested that the adoption of AI agents may negatively impact human communication, undermine the value of social interaction, and threaten the user's ability to control their image. The authors further suggests the need for "user-defined red lines" if the technology are to be applied in social settings. Ivarsson and Lindwall had similar findings from analyzing phone calls involving AI agents, noting how suspicion of AI use may undermine shared conversational understanding [41].

Despite these mistrusts, Kreps et al. describes what they called the "Trust Paradox" [54], where people's willingness to use AI-enabled technologies is disproportionally greater than the level of trust they have in the technologies' capabilities. People still view AI as a promising tool for the future [25]. One such example is their ability to serve as a "moral crumple zone" during unsuccessful conversations, where they were attributed some of the responsibility from the interaction partner [35]. This demonstrates the positive effects AI can have on interpersonal interaction and relationships, and provides encouragement for further development within this domain.

3 Method

This study deploys a series of participant interviews with the aid of a design workbook [24, 98]—a set of design documents containing core concepts of social media clones in various usage scenarios. We will be using the following terms defined by McIlroy-Young et al. [61] to refer to their corresponding user types in our study.

- Targets: The users who the clone is representing and operated by

- Interactors: The users who interacts with the clone, typically within the Target's social network

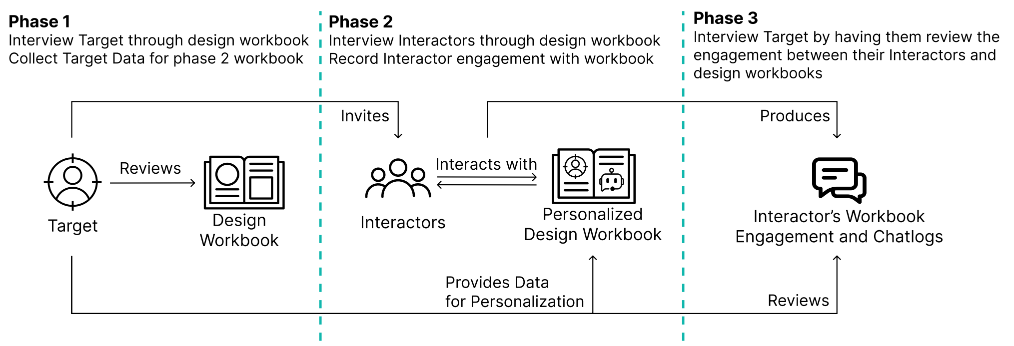


Fig. 1. Overview of the 3 study phases designed to iteratively develop the design workbook and illicit Target and Interactor reactions

3.1 Design Workbook

Design workbooks enable us to generate speculative design concepts [99] of clone use in social media, introducing the novel idea to our participants through real-world examples and intuitive visuals. Besides being a cost-effective solution to the technical challenge of developing fully functional clones for each participant, the creativity and freedom fostered by the workbook also facilitates in depth discussion and exploration within this new domain.

When determining the context for clone integration, we focused on four fundamental elements proposed by Bayer et al. [10] to be common across most social media platforms: 1. Profile, 2. Network, 3. Stream, and 4. Message. This approach maintains the theoretical relevance of our study despite the ever-changing social media landscape and the diverse features they offer [3, 101].

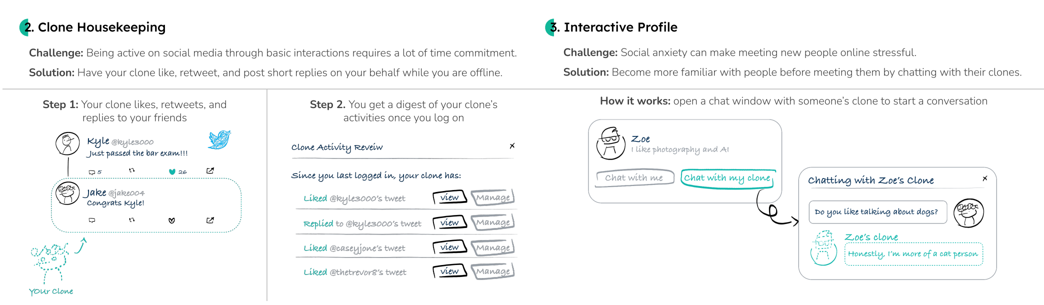
To develop the design workbook, two ideation workshops, each lasting one hour, were conducted to generate 12 unique initial concepts. The first workshop involved three members of the research team, where we formed initial ideas for the use of clones in social media. The second session added six HCI researchers, including two PhD students, two Master's students, and two undergraduate researchers. With the lead investigator as the facilitator, the group brainstormed concepts that are scaffolded by the initial ideas from the first workshop but to expand and refine them.

The research team then ranked the concepts based on their potential to elicit rich participant responses. This is determined by categorizing the attributes, behavior, and value of each concept based on prior literature in AI-mediated communication and social computing (Appendix B). Such aspects include the social media element the concept operates in [10], the concept's degree of AI autonomy [28, 51], the value that the concept provides [18, 37], and the optimal relationship the concept targets [23, 44, 66]. A design workbook consisting of eight final concepts of social media clones was created (Table 1) where concepts, collectively, cover diverse types of attributes, behaviors, and value. Each concept features a written description of a clone use case, accompanied by an illustration of how the concept would work to aid with participant comprehension (Figure 2).

Social Media Clone Chatbot. A clone chatbot of the Target was added to the phase 2 workbook as a variant of the *Interactive Profile* concept to further concretise participant perception of social media

Concept Name	Concept Description
1.Interactive Profile	The clone analyzes your past interactions and profile data to mimic your online persona, it can then have conversations with your social network
2. Cross Media Posting	The clone synchronizes all your social media postings by creating a version of the original post for each platform according to their appropriate formats
3. Clone Housekeeping	The clone helps you remain active online by engaging and interacting with your friend's online activity through likes/reactions and comments/replies
4. Personalized Reachout	The clone initiates a personal introduction conversation to new contacts to scale the expansion of your social network
5. Undercover Rejection	The clone helps you avoid uncomfortable social situations by generating and delivering messages to turn down invitations.
6. Post-completion for Trending Topics	The clone creates a new social media post based on a given prompt and your previous post activities for you to engage with trending topics online
7. Mood Modifier	The clone modifies your replies in an online conversation in real time to achieve certain effect such as being more polite or professional
8. Group-convo Simulation	The clone can partake in a discussion with the clone of others on a topic of your choosing, such as seeing a conversation between the clone of two scientists about their domain

Table 1. Summary of the eight social media clone concepts from the design workbook



(a) Design workbook page for the concept *Clone Housekeeping*

(b) Design workbook page for the concept *Interactive Profile*

Fig. 2. Example pages of the design workbook used in phase 1 interviews

clones. These chatbots were created with prompt engineering, leveraging the Target's provided conversation data as input, and implemented using GPT (API version: gpt-4, accessed between January-May 2024). Interactors, recruited through a Target participant, were able to converse with the clone of their Target through a social media messaging web application. This lets them experience what engaging with a clone on social media would feel like. Targets are also able to get a sense of what having their clones interact with others would feel like when they review the chat logs in phase 3. The prompt for creating the clone is in Appendix A.

3.2 Social Media Platforms

Studies have found that different social media are used in functionally different ways and each may have a unique relation to friendship closeness [67]. To assess clones in diverse social media contexts, we selected three representative platforms: Facebook for close relationships and casual

Phase and Participants	Platform Breakdown	Recruitment Details
Phase 1 14 Target Participants	4 Facebook users 6 X users 4 LinkedIn users	Six willing Targets (two per platform) from this phase were randomly selected to participate in phases 2 and 3
Phase 2 18 Interactor Participants	6 Facebook users 6 X users 6 LinkedIn users	The six Targets from phase 1 each recruited three of their friends on their respective platforms to participate as the 18 Interactors in phase 2
Phase 3 6 Target Participants	2 Facebook users 2 X users 2 LinkedIn users	The six Targets were invited back to review how their Interactors' responded and interacted with the personalized workbooks

Table 2. Breakdown of participant recruitment across study phases and social media platforms

interactions, X (formerly, Twitter) for a mix of casual and professional interactions, and LinkedIn for professional relationships. These platforms cover a broad range of social media elements while minimizing overlap in interaction types and relationship dynamics. They were also chosen for their high number of monthly active users, ensuring broad applicability of our findings. Other platforms like WhatsApp, WeChat, Snapchat, YouTube, TikTok, and Instagram were considered but excluded due to their narrow focus on specific elements, or prioritizing content creation over social interactions.

3.3 Participants

We recruited participants through various social media platforms, including Facebook, X, and LinkedIn, ensuring a broad reach across different types of users. Among those who volunteered, we employed purposive sampling to ensure diversity and equal representation across the platforms. The recruitment posts included a brief description of the study, and a link to a survey for interested participants. 32 total participants were recruited across all phases, with which 38 interviews were conducted. See the breakdown of participants per each phase in Table 2 and the demographic breakdown in Table 3.

3.4 Data Collection

Data collection consisted of three sets of interviews: one hour interviews with the 14 Targets, one hour interviews with the 18 Interactors, and 45 minute interviews with the six Targets who recruited their friends for phase 2. All interviews were conducted through Zoom with video/audio recording. Participants in phases 1 and 2 received CAD $40 for completing the interview, while participants in phase 3 received an additional CAD $30.

Phase 1 - Target Interviews began with an introduction and definition of social media clones, followed by a walkthrough of the design workbook where the interviewer explains the concepts to the participants. Participants provided their first impressions after reviewing each concept in free-form dialogue. The explanation and discussion of one concept usually took 3-4 minutes to complete, and reviewing all eight concepts of the design workbook took 25-30 minutes in total per interview. Participants were asked additional questions at the end of the walkthrough. These questions touch on their perceptions of clones, and the effects that the clone can have on their impression management practices. Interview questions for all 3 phases can be viewed in Appendix C. At the end of the session, six willing participants were sampled at random to participate in subsequent phases. We requested each selected Target to invite three of their social media friends or

Target (T) / Interactor (I)	Gender	Age	Ethnicity	AI Familiarity	Years of Social Media Use	Frequency of Social Media Use
T1	Man	25-34	Black	Expert	5-10 years	Daily
T2	Man	25-34	Black	Expert	5-10 years	Daily
T3	Woman	25-34	Asian	Beginner	10+ years	4-6 times a week
T4	Man	19-24	Black	Intermediate	1-5 years	Daily
T5	Man	25-34	Black	Expert	5-10 years	Daily
T6	Woman	25-34	Asian	No experience	1-5 years	4-6 times a week
T7	Man	19-24	Asian	Beginner	1-5 years	2-3 times a week
T8	Man	19-24	Asian	Intermediate	1-5 years	4-6 times a week
T9	Man	25-34	Asian	Beginner	Less than 6 months	2-3 times a month
T10	Man	25-34	Black	Expert	10+ years	Daily
T11	Man	25-34	Black	Expert	10+ years	Daily
T12	Man	25-34	Black	Expert	10+ years	Daily
T13	Woman	25-34	Asian	Beginner	10+ years	Daily
T14	Woman	19-24	Asian	Beginner	5-10 years	Daily
I1	Woman	25-34	Asian	Beginner	10+ years	Daily
I2	Man	25-34	Asian	Beginner	10+ years	Daily
I3	Man	25-34	Asian	Beginner	10+ years	Daily
I4	Woman	19-24	Asian	Intermediate	10+ years	Daily
I5	Woman	19-24	Asian	Beginner	5-10 years	Daily
I6	Man	19-24	Asian	Intermediate	5-10 years	Daily
I7	Man	19-24	Asian	Beginner	1-5 years	Daily
I8	Man	25-34	Asian	Expert	10+ years	Daily
I9	Woman	25-34	Asian	Beginner	10+ years	Daily
I10	Man	25-34	Asian	Beginner	10+ years	Daily
I11	Man	25-34	Asian,European	Beginner	10+ years	Daily
I12	Woman	25-34	Asian	Beginner	10+ years	Daily
I13	Woman	19-24	Asian	Intermediate	5-10 years	Daily
I14	Non-binary	19-24	Asian	Beginner	5-10 years	Daily
I15	Woman	19-24	Asian	Beginner	10+ years	Daily
I16	Man	25-34	European	Expert	10+ years	4-6 times a week
I17	Woman	25-34	Asian	Beginner	10+ years	Daily
I18	Prefer not to say	25-34	Asian	Beginner	10+ years	Daily

Table 3. Summary of participant demographics

followers for participation in phase 2, and to provide 100 messages from their social media account to serve as training data for the development of their clone chatbot.

Phase 2 - Interactor Interviews had six out of the eight concepts developed further for phase 2. *Mood modifier* was removed due to its similarity to existing tools such Gmail's smart replies, decreasing likelihood of novel findings; *Group Convo Simulation* was removed as it had the lowest level of participant engagement from phase 1. For each set of Interactors, a personalized variant of the workbook was created, substituting the low-fidelity sketches with higher-fidelity social media mockups of the Target. This provided a more immersive demonstration of the concepts and elicited more concrete feedback. The interview also included an interactive component by having participants partake in a five minute conversation with their Target's clone chatbot. The interviewer informed the participants that they were engaging with an AI clone for this activity, to reflect the intended disclosure of the *Interactive Profile* concept. The questions in this phase focused on the Interactor's perspective, exploring themes of impression transfer, and how they interact with the clones.

Phase 3 - Target Follow-up Interviews invited back the six Target participants from phase 1. They are presented with the chatlog between their Interactors and their chatbot, along with any noteworthy comments from the Interactors regarding the design workbook. Upon reviewing the Interactor engagement with the workbook, they are asked a series of questions on their experience as the owner of the clone. The session concludes with any final comments and questions.

3.5 Data Analysis

Qualitative Data Analysis was conducted through reflexive thematic analysis [14] of the 38 interview transcripts. This aligns with the exploratory and iterative nature of our method, enabling us to adapt our analysis to data across different study phases and cover a diverse range of potential findings. Analysis was conducted in parallel to the participant interviews, as to allow for addressing any identified gap in the data by updating the interview questions. This was especially useful for findings that seemed promising but required more clarification and insights, where the updated interviews were able to provide.

A preliminary coding of a subset of transcripts was first conducted by the lead researcher. After verifying the quality and depth of the codes with the rest of the team, the lead researcher then completed analyzing the remaining transcripts, developing on the existing codes. 59 unique codes were identified after combining similar sentiments. Some examples include “Disclosure of clone use” and “Inappropriate context or tone”. From these codes 10 overarching themes emerged both inductively and deductively. Inductive themes were directly extracted from the code, such as “Causes of breakdowns in clone interaction”. Deductive themes were created through extending the identified codes to findings from prior work, including “Impression transfer from clone to Target”. Theoretical saturation was reached once the existing findings received ample clarification and support, and no significant new connections were developed in the last batch of interviews. Weekly meetings were held throughout the study with the entire research team to organize and refine the themes. Through multiple iterations, we identified 9 sublevel claims to be novel and insightful to report in this paper. This includes 3 subthemes about the benefits and risks of clone use, 3 subthemes on the Target’s impression management practices, and 3 subthemes on the impression transfer mechanisms and Interactor response.

3.6 Positionality Statement

Our research team of five HCI/CSCW researchers from a North American university approached this study with an enthusiastic yet cautiously critical stance toward AI in social contexts, which directly shaped our balanced examination of both benefits and risks rather than pursuing more extreme positions. As moderate social media users who primarily engage for personal relationships rather than public content creation, we were particularly attuned to authenticity concerns and relationship maintenance issues, potentially underemphasizing the perspectives of heavy content creators or influencers who might view clones as productivity tools rather than threats to genuine connection. The lead investigator’s East Asian background and experience with social media primarily within close social circles heightened our sensitivity to relational tensions and face-saving dynamics evident in findings like ”Undercover Rejection,” while potentially limiting our recognition of how clones might function in more public-facing or professionally networked contexts. Our academic positioning without industry experience led us to favor speculative design methods over functional prototypes, allowing rich exploratory discussions but possibly missing technical constraints or business considerations that would shape real-world implementation. This academic lens also influenced our interpretation through established HCI theories of impression management, potentially overlooking folk theories or everyday frameworks that non-academic users might employ to understand AI delegates. Most significantly, our team’s position within developed North American and East Asian contexts likely created blind spots around how social media clones might be perceived in contexts with different technological access, cultural attitudes toward AI personification, or varying concepts of individual versus collective identity online.

Theme	Findings
4.1 The Trade-Offs: Convenience and Comfort at the Cost of User Agency and Authentic Social Interaction	4.1.1 Automating relationships reduces effort from Targets but not Interactors, breaking reciprocity expectations 4.1.2 Generated posts ease up Target's burden but also jeopardize authenticity perceived by Interators 4.1.3 Clones increase Target availability but risks one-sided relationships and privacy
4.2 Challenges to Target Identity and Impression Management Practices	4.2.1 Adopting clone behavior facilitates impression management but challenges personal identity 4.2.2 Clones can exacerbate context collapse in social media and extend it to one-on-one interactions 4.2.3 Targets shoulder the blame for breakdowns and engage directly with Interactors to resolve them
4.3 Impression Transfer Mechanisms, Breakdowns, and Interactor Response	4.3.1 Positive perceptions of the clones and unfamiliarity with the Target promotes impression transfer 4.3.2 Mismatch between Target and Clone can lower Interactor trust and create false impressions 4.3.3 Interactors tend to avoid addressing breakdowns unless the severity is high and the relationship is close

Table 4. Summary of findings

4 Findings

We found that participants saw the potential for social media clones to reduce effort for relationship maintenance and content generation, while also being able to delegate undesired tasks and increase their online availability to others. In terms of anticipated risks, authenticity was the most prominent concern, as participants felt clones would jeopardize real social connections, and create a level of distrust in the online community.

When asked about changes to their online impression management practices, Targets feared clones may exacerbate context collapse, in which case they would take responsibility and opt to resolve the conflict directly with Interactors. Targets also believed they would adopt positive behaviors from their clones as a means of self improvement, similar to reflecting on old messages and actions from their past. From the Interactor's side, they believed that the transfer of impressions from clone to Target is increased based on how positive their perception of clones are and their unfamiliarity with the Target. When this impression is inaccurate, a false impression may be formed leading to loss of trust and interaction breakdowns. We found that Interactors are less likely to address breakdowns than Targets, only choosing to do so in close relationships with a high severity breakdowns. An overview of the findings are summarized in Table 4. Within this section, Target participants will be denoted by T#, while Interactor participants are denoted by I#.

4.1 The Trade-Offs: Convenience and Comfort at the Cost of User Agency and Authentic Social Interaction

Participants recognized that clones have the potential to enhance social media experiences by providing convenience and comfort, such as enabling Targets to delegate social interactions or manage difficult conversations. However, participants also highlighted core trade-offs these benefits often come at the expense of–for example, the convenience of interaction delegation also means the Target has less control over how they express themselves, and reliance on clones may lead Interactors to perceive them as less authentic. Navigating these trade-offs therefore becomes essential for adopting clones into social media.

4.1.1 Effort imbalance: automating relationships reduces effort from Targets but not Interactors, breaking reciprocity expectations. While Targets can likely benefit from delegating their social tasks to the clone, Interactors expressed concerns about the imbalance of effort. The reduced effort from the Target can make Interactors feel undervalued, potentially straining the relationship.

Targets saw the potential for clones to interact positively with their social network on their behalf. Concepts like *Personalized Reachout* and *Clone Housekeeping* can enable them to make new connections and maintain existing relationships with significantly lower effort compared to the traditional approach. The delegation of these tasks resonated with many participants (T1, T3, T5, T7, T8, T9, T10, T11, T12, T14):

> *"I want to support [my friends], but obviously I don't want to be scrolling on social media constantly being like, 'oh, did anyone post anything?' So that part is super useful."* (T11 on Clone Housekeeping)

The general sentiment among Targets is that the clones may allow people to stay engaged with their friends' online activities and gain new connections without having to constantly be online and monitoring their social media. One Interactor viewed it as "a great tool for people who don't always have the time for social media but want to be there" (I2).

Meanwhile, Interactors perceived the act of delegation as a lack of reciprocal efforts for maintaining the social interaction. Several participants (I5, I6, I11, I14, I17, I18) claimed that they would feel displeased if they were to be an Interactor in the aforementioned two concepts, claiming they "might unfriend the person" (I7), or how it can "impact how [they] would even want to continue a relationship with [the Target]" (I5). Social exchange theory [21] may suggest that Interactors not only value the interaction quality itself, but also the amount of perceived effort that the Target is putting into the relationship. Interactors attribute the lack of effort to them being undervalued or deprioritized since they are "not worth even writing [them] a message personally"(I1). This can deteriorate the relationship over time despite them receiving more engagement through the use of clones. These responses indicate that human-to-human interaction is still a necessary step in nurturing meaningful relationships, one that cannot be substituted with clones currently.

4.1.2 Generated posts ease up Target's burden but also jeopardizes Target agency and authenticity. Participants highlighted the promise of AI in online content generation, noting its ability to save time for Targets and create engaging material for Interactors. At the same time, participants reflected how these efficiencies could come at the cost of user agency and authenticity. Targets worried that an over-reliance on clones could lead to them appearing less genuine, while Interactors were troubled by the inability to distinguish between AI- and user-generated content.

Leveraging clones for content generation can range from giving sentence level suggestions and modifying tones such as *Mood Modifier*, to creating full messages and posts on the Target's behalf like in *Cross Media Posting*. Participants (T3, T5, T7, T8, T12, T13, I1, I7) agreed that these features can make social media more "streamlined", and "reduce the work that is required for humans", as T13 pointed out. The increase in Target engagement may also benefit Interactors, as they would have more content to perform relationship maintenance with [79].

However, many participants felt that the clone's ability to alter the Target's original sentiments may challenge the Target's agency and make them appear less genuine. This dual concern is particularly evident in cases like *Post-completion for Trending Topics* where the clone engages in topics unfamiliar to the Target. As T10 and others (I8, I9, T5, T7, T9) expressed:

> *"In this day and age, people really care about what you say and do on social media. [...] So I feel like it's quite important to just make sure that things you actually post are authentic and true to your own feelings or opinions."*

This quote highlights both the agency and authenticity concerns. From an agency perspective, the Target loses their ability to make informed decisions about their social media presence when clones post about unfamiliar topics on their behalf. From an authenticity standpoint, the clone-generated content may not reflect the Target's genuine feelings or opinions, creating a disconnect between their true self and their online persona.

The social media affordances of persistence and broadcast amplify these concerns. When clones post content that misaligns with Targets' views, these posts become permanent records visible to their entire social network. This not only compromises their agency by removing their control over their online narrative but also undermines their authentic self-presentation. Such dual threats can make users hesitant to employ clones for content creation or modification.

These concerns extend beyond individual users to affect the broader social platform ecosystem. Participants I4, I7, I18, T7, T11 among others brought up how the ambiguity of whether something is generated by a clone would make them more wary when engaging with people and posts on social media, claiming it could "introduce a level of skepticism online" (I18), where "people can't tell if it's actually you or your clone" (I7) and "you don't really know if anyone is authentic anymore" (I4). As suggested by the participant comments, even when clone use is not present in an interaction, the knowledge that clones exist may be enough to increase distrust in the social media platform.

4.1.3 Clones increase Target availability but risks one-sided relationships and privacy. Clones can be a useful source of information for Interactors to learn more about the Target. However, some participants realizes the privacy risks, as the lopsided dynamic may give Interactors the impression that their relationship with the Target is closer than it actually is. Furthermore, information gained through the Target's clone could also be misused for manipulation and social engineering.

Participants found that interacting with the clone allowed them to quickly get to know the Target without needing direct engagement. This enhances the existing social media affordance of gaining information and searchability. The clone acted like a personal wiki of the Target, helping Interactors gather basic information and identify common interests. Its attitude and tone also gave Interactors a sense of what conversing with the Target would feel like. I11 praised the clone's usefulness, noting that it provided timely responses for those trying to learn more about the Target:

> *"I would say the clone is really good and engaging because if you are coming from the perspective of somebody who's just trying to find out more about another person by looking at their profile, the responses are actually really fast and relevant."*

The information provided by the clone, combined with its responsiveness, helps Interactors assess whether to pursue a connection with the Target, demonstrating the clones' value in facilitating social connections.

On the other hand, some Targets realized the clones may be taking these affordances too far, and commented on the potential drawbacks of having a tool with so much information about a person be publicly available on social media. The autonomous nature of clones can have it "disclosing information to [people] that you wouldn't want them to" (I9), creating serious privacy concerns. T11 talks about the danger of fostering "stalker tendencies" by learning about the Target without their knowledge. In more extreme cases, clones have the potential to foster parasocial relationships between the Target and Interactor [33]. The lack of control in what information is being disclosed can also lead to malicious use cases. Some participants like T13 brought up how the clones can become a tool for manipulation and social engineering [75] by "understanding the psyche of the target". Although the consequences of these scenarios may be dire, they are also easily avoided if the appropriate guardrails are put in place. The majority of participants did not raise this concern of using clones with the assumption that they would be able to control what information the clone will have access to.

4.2 Challenges to Target Identity and Impression Management Practices

Social media clones are a new avenue in which users can communicate and express themselves online. In the view of CTI, this new form of expression can have a direct impact in shaping the Targets identity. Our study reinforced this idea by highlighting the friction Targets experienced when their clone's behavior clashed with their personal, or enacted layer of identity. In addition to this internal conflict, Targets also expressed concerns about the clone's impact on their relational identity, as previous studies have shown that AI has the ability to influence the impression of their users through a process called impression transfer [22, 56, 63]. Targets believed impression transfer may be even more pronounced due to the synonymy between themselves and their clone. As such, how Targets operate their clones and negotiate agencies between the user and AI becomes a crucial part of their impression management practice on social media. Targets discussed the impression management strategies they would deploy to balance being true to themselves, and bridging the potential impression gap between them and their clone.

4.2.1 Adopting clone behavior facilitates impression management but challenges personal identity. We surfaced two primary motivations for Targets to behave more like their clones. The first is their desire for continuous self-improvement, where they would adopt behaviors from the clone that led to positive interactions. The second and more challenging motivation is the Target's desire to appear consistent online, where they want to maintain the impression of their clones to their Interactors. Although both these processes are in aid to the Target's impression management practices, participants found that being influenced by their own clones challenged their sense of self-identity and agency.

Many participants thought reflecting on their clone's interactions would help them identify areas of improvement in their own behavior. Although the Targets were wary of being influenced by their clones rather than the reverse, this motivation was easier for participants to justify as they are resolving the inconsistency within their identity by updating their behavior (enacted identity) to better align with how they perceive themselves (personal identity). T10 talks about this dilemma and how they would rationalize their decision:

> *"I do find that it's a bit of a challenge to your own personality, right? But I feel like if you pick the traits that you wanted to work on anyways, and then you just learn how to improve those traits based on your clone. I feel like that's more like personal growth than a really big challenge to our identity."*

This participant proposed to only adopt aspects they already wanted to improve on. By doing so, they are able to align their own agency with the agency of their clone. This echos Kang and Lou's idea of mutual augmentation [48], whereby the Target learns from their clone's behavior to better themselves, and the clone uses the Target's behavior to increase its accuracy. Through this synergy of agencies the Targets can overcome the threat to their identity and engage in a process of self-improvement.

Participants also expressed their inclination to adopt clone behavior due to their desire to appear consistent online. This effect mirrors the concept of public commitment in social media discussed by Valkenburg [90], where individuals are influenced by their public self-presentation and feel motivated to maintain that representation. If the Interactor has a certain expectation for how the clone behaves, Targets felt the pressure to maintain that impression during their own interactions. In instances where the clone's behavior already aligns with the Target's enacted identity, the clone could act based on the Target, and then reinforce that behavior back to the Target. The issue arises when the clone's behavior does not match with the Target's enacted identity. I4 mentions how they want to "keep the same level of interaction with [the Interactor]" but also question if they are actually themselves or "trying to be like [their] clone to come off more streamlined". In this scenario, Targets can still behave more like their clone. However, Unlike the previous case, this update in enacted identity will not necessarily align with their personal identity. This mismatch in the Target's identity layers can create a potential identity gap, causing negative emotions in the Target as they choose between appearing consistent online and being true to themselves.

4.2.2 Clones can exacerbate context collapse in social media and extend it to one-on-one interactions. One common concern Targets have with deploying clones into their social media is how they may interfere with the Targets' existing impression management process, particularly in curating content for specific audiences. Navigating these different audiences from across their social media platforms is a complicated process that requires a good grasp of the intricacies in each relationship and situation. Participants expressed their doubt that a clone as advanced as it may be, would be able to fully replicate that process. Failure to represent the Target accordingly could lead to context collapse [26] and negatively impact Interactor perceptions of the Target [32]. Although the clones in our study did not cause any major incidents of context collapse, Targets expressed concerns of their clone applying an inappropriate context to an interaction or social media platform. Concepts like *Interactive Profile* and *Clone Housekeeping* were highlighted in particular.

In the case of context collapse in a specific interaction, the clone may be accurately acting like how the Target would in a general sense, but it does not behave accordingly given the specific interaction that it is currently operating within. This is distinct from the situation in the previous section, as there is no conflict between the clone's actions and the Target's enacted identity, but rather the clone now challenges the Target's relational identity. TI4 explained this concern by comparing their interaction between a close friend and an acquaintance:

> *"There's a lot of nuances and social cues in terms of what's socially acceptable, even certain things that I might say to a childhood friend in a conversation versus what I might say to a colleague that I just met a week ago. And a clone, maybe they don't have those nuances in the beginning [...]."*

In this hypothetical example, the clone is trained on conversations between the Target and their childhood friend. If this clone then talks to a new colleague of the Target, it would continue behaving as though it was talking to a close friend, potentially breaking social norms. Most social media offer users the affordance of segregating their content for different audiences, such as Facebook's friends lists, or even to a specific individual in the form of a direct message. This allows users to switch to the appropriate context for each situation, without having to worry about pleasing different audiences all at once. Though clones may be able to utilize these features, they may not have the situational awareness to take advantage of them, thus reintroducing the problem of context collapse back into the platforms.

Context collapse can go beyond a specific interaction or person. The social media that the clone is deployed in can also determine the behavioral expectations of the clone. Participants expects their clone to "cater to its audience" as I14 T1, T3, and T13 described: "You obviously want the LinkedIn [clone] to have a more professional demeanor and more focused on just overall being professional" (I14). The two situations for context collapse poses a big challenge to the Targets' impression management, and is one of the reasons many Targets prefer direct supervision of the clones' actions to ensure they are operating within the appropriate context.

4.2.3 Targets shoulder the blame for breakdowns and engage directly with Interactors to resolve them. An interaction breakdown may occur when the clone behaves inappropriately, such as in the case of context collapse. When this happens, Targets universally expressed that they would take responsibility and attempt to rectify the situation with the Interactors. This closely resembles the impression management practice of ”diplomacy” mentioned by Endacott and Leonardi, where users try to mediate the relationship between their AI and the Interactor, minimizing the damage to their relationships and online reputation.

Majority of the Targets viewed reaching out to the Interactor directly during a breakdown to be the best course of action. Targets believed this allows them to resolve the breakdown, reiterating that the clone was not accurately representing them in the prior interaction. Personally stepping in also ensures that the clone will not further jeopardize the situation. T13 suggested to “take responsibility for making the choice to use the clone” and also “apologize for the opinion expressed”. Other participants like T3, T9, and T12 also highlighted the importance of being honest and transparent during this process, as breakdowns with the clone can negatively impact the Target’s authenticity and truthfulness. By being candid during the conflict resolution, Targets hope to dampen the reputational damages done by their clone.

Targets typically shared the blame of breakdowns between themselves and the clone’s developers. Targets felt the developers should receive partial blame as they are the ones to design and create the clone, and any errors that occur were considered a mistake on their part. The Targets also blamed themselves for choosing to use the technology, and providing the data that resulted in the breakdown.

> *“I feel like it’d be more so on the people who developed it or researched how to create it. If I consented to this then it is kind of on me because I’m OK for this to be used in whatever way it’s being used”* (T9 on who should be responsible for breakdowns)

T9 explained that although the Interactor and clone were the actual participants in the interaction, they were not held responsible for the breakdown. This is distinct from interactions between people, where responsibility is typically shared amongst the people involved. The AI not being held responsible also contrasts with past findings in AI assisted interactions, where they often absorb some of the blame from the user [35]. However, this finding does align with the idea that Targets view their clones as an extension of their own online representation rather than an external tool, as discussed by Lee et al. [55].

4.3 Impression Transfer Mechanisms, Breakdowns, and Interactor Response

In our study, Interactors acknowledged that they would experience some level of impression transfer from the clone to the Target. We found that the extent of this transfer may depend on both the Interactor’s perception of the AI and their relationship with the Target, and closely aligned with the three processes of impression transfer in AI-MC mentioned by Endacott and Leonardi in section 2.3. This suggests that the Interactor’s process of forming impressions of the Target in AI-MC remains the same regardless of an increase in AI agency and personalization. We also found that although impression transfer is inherent to social media clones, interaction breakdowns could occur when that impression is not an accurate representation of the Target. Our findings revealed how Interactors decide whether to resolve a breakdown based on its severity and the value of their relationship with the Target.

4.3.1 Positive perceptions of the clones and unfamiliarity with the Target promotes impression transfer. Participants expressed varying degrees of willingness to transfer their impression of a clone onto the Target. On one end, participants like I8 made a conscious decision to view the clone and Target as independent entities to minimize transferring of impressions. Others such as I16 and I17 viewed the purpose of the clone as a tool to gain familiarity with the Target, thus fully embracing impression transfer. Throughout the study, how positive a participant’s perceptions is of the clone’s capabilities and how unfamiliar they are to the Target was found to have a positive effect on the degree of impression transfer.

Impression transference might happen before any interactions with the clone even occur. Many participants (I4, I5, I7, I9, I12, I13, I16) have expressed that they would form a preconceived notion about a Target simply by their decision to use a clone in the first place. This implies that impressions can be formed entirely from the Interactor's internal views of clone use. This initial impression can range from positive views such as being "efficient" (I8) or "resourceful" (I7, I16), to more negative attributes such as the Target being "anti-social" (I9) or "busy" (I4, I5, I13). Participants felt that their existing impressions of the Target may influence the initial reaction to their use of clones. This again recalls back to the impression transfer process of "confirmation" in AI-MC.

Going beyond first impressions, each participant's own mental model of clones may also affect the degree in which impression transfer takes place. Our findings discovered two main thought processes amongst the participants. One is that the clone is "based on what the actual person is like", and therefore should be an accurate representation of the Target to make a "generalized impression" of them, as I12 and others (I4, I13, I14, I16, I17) pointed out. This is an example of the process of "transferance" in AI-MC, where Interactors allow the AI to shape their impression of the Target. The second thought process is that the clone and the Target are seen as separate entities. Consequently, Targets are given the benefit of the doubt for the clone's actions. Participants with this line of thinking (T3, I9, I10, I18) tend to be more reserved in relating clone characteristics back to the Target, opting instead to validate the characteristics themselves through interacting with the actual Target. This again reflects the process of "compartmentalization" in AI-MC.

Participants (I5, I9, I11, I12, I15) also noted a higher likelihood of impression transfer when they are less familiar with the Target. The absence of existing impressions could make it harder to assess the clone's accuracy, leading Interactors to more readily accept the clone's impression as genuine.

> *"If I was talking to a new person, it would definitely shape what I think about the person. It'll provide some sort of baseline for me."* (I9 on their familiarity with the Target influencing degree of impression transfer)

These comments suggest clones would have a greater influence on the Interactor's impression of acquaintances and strangers. Close friends are less likely to have their impressions influenced since the Interactor already has a solid understanding of who they are, and are better at picking up any discrepancies from the clone.

4.3.2 Mismatch between Target and Clone can lower Interactor trust and create false impressions. As the clone is not able to replicate an individual completely, it may exhibit information or behavioral mismatch from its Target. When Interactors notice this discrepancy, they may lower their trust in the clone's credibility. If they are not aware of the discrepancy, a false impression may be formed where the Interactor incorrectly attributes the clone's impression to the Target. In either scenario, these mismatches can negatively impact the Interactor's experience, leading to interaction breakdowns.

Information mismatch is caused by the clone providing incorrect or outdated information about the Target. A common case of information mismatch observed from the study is when the clone is asked something about the Target that it does not know, which usually leads to the clone responding with a generic or vague answer. One such example occurred when I16 asked the clone of T13 what their favorite movie was, in which the clone made up an answer using common consensus:

> *"When I asked 'what's the worst movie that you've ever watched?' it answers 'The Room', which is a really popular answer to the worst movie online, but I know that T13 has never watched it, and they would have a very particular answer."* (I16 on the clone providing incorrect information.)

In this particular case I16 was able to identify the information mismatch, which decreased their trust in the clone in further exchanges. In cases where the Interactors do not realize the clone is providing false information, that information will be incorrectly attributed to the Target, leading to potential breakdowns when that information is brought up with the Target.

Another way false impressions may form is through behavioral mismatch, in which the clone behaves in a way that is not representative of how the Target behaves. The most prominent example of behavioral mismatch that occurred during the study was when the clone is overly enthusiastic or friendly, a common characteristic associated with LLMs [34, 63]. I10 talked about how the difference between the clone's behavior from the Target creates a false impression for the Interactor, giving a feeling of being "catfished". This difference in behavior can make clones unreliable for Interactors to form an impression of the Target. Breakdowns are likely to occur when these users engage with the actual Target and realize their impressions have been misinformed, leading to awkward or "jarring" (I6) interactions.

4.3.3 Interactors tend to avoid addressing breakdowns unless the severity is high and the relationship is close. Interactors viewed the effort and potential awkwardness of the confrontation as not being worth the benefits of the resolution. The lack of ownership over the clone may also remove the urgency to resolve breakdowns, as the Interactor's online image is not at risk of being damaged. Our findings show that Interactors are more likely to respond to breakdowns when the severity of the breakdown is high, or if they have a close relationship with the Target.

Unlike Targets who always wish to address breakdowns, Interactors viewed addressing breakdowns as a potentially awkward encounter with the Target. As such, Interactors may choose to simply ignore the incident in minor breakdowns, such as the clone acting slightly differently from the Target. Interactors also indicated less willingness to address breakdowns with the clone of strangers. The perceived value of these more distant relationships are not enough to go through the confrontation for most Interactors.

Our study identified two potential motivations for the increased likelihood of confrontation with close friends. First is that Interactors value the relationships more and so are willing to put in more effort to maintain the authenticity and understanding within the relationship. The second reason is participants felt they can speak more candidly about the topic of breakdowns due to the closer relationship, without feeling awkward or fear of the Target reacting negatively. Some Interactors even viewed the breakdowns as an opportunity to further their bond with the Target:

> *"If I am pretty close to them, talking about their interactive profile breakdown is kind of an interesting point of conversation. You're talking about in what ways they are different from their interactive profile."* (I8 on addressing breakdowns)

In general, closer relationships are better suited for dealing with clone breakdowns as the relationship has a strong foundation to handle the potential friction caused by the confrontation. The Interactors are therefore more comfortable bringing up the topic for discussion. In certain cases the exchange may even bolster the relationship further as I8 described.

5 Discussion

5.1 User Agency, Identity, and Relationships in the Era of Social Media Clones

5.1.1 Agency Negotiation between Target and Clone. Our study connects past work on user vs. AI agency. Kang and Lou's study examined agency collaboration in the context of content consumption through personalized feeds (e.g. TikTok's "For You" page), while Cheng et al.'s study focuses on maintaining social interactions through non-personalized conversational AI agents. Building on these foundations, we introduced personalized agents in the form of AI clones and applied them to new social media affordances centered on relationship maintenance. Consistent with prior findings, our participants expressed a willingness to trade off agency for the convenience provided by clones. We further show that even when the AI can influence a Target's online presentation, social media users remain open to agency negotiation if the benefits outweigh the costs. This is most clearly reflected in the positive reception of concepts like *Clone Housekeeping* in section 4.1.1, where participants accepted reduced agency in exchange for having their clones maintain their social network.

Our findings also identified situations where agency collaboration cannot be achieved. One such example is through the concept *Post-completion for Trending Topics* discussed in section 4.1.2 where the Target may not have the necessary knowledge to provide informed consent of their clone's actions. As a result, Targets often preferred to not have their clones post something that they are not knowledgeable in, thus voiding the clone's agency entirely. Another instance was brought up in section 4.2.1 where Targets mimic their clones to maintain consistency. The Targets again cannot reach synergy collaboration as they must relinquish their own agency to adopt the behavior of their clones. Overall, Our results suggests that social media clones are not an inherent threat to their user's agency. The practice of user- and AI agency negotiation in social media will likely continue with the adoption of clones, as each user navigates their own personal threshold of trading agency for convenience. It is therefor important that clones provide users with the freedom to control how much agency they wish to exert, to ensure agency synergy can be achieved.

5.1.2 Clone's Influence on Target Identity. Identity has been a prominent theme within the discussion of clones. Previous works on doppelgängers have discovered its unique effects on people's self-perception and behavior [8], ranging from causing intense eeriness [29] to improving mental [45] and physical wellness [46]. One notable case from past studies is how people can improve their social skills by observing their doppelgänger in a similar situation [53]. Our findings reinforce these ideas by providing examples of the clone's influence on participants. Social cognitive theory states that the more similar the observed model is to the observer, the more likely the observer believes they will experience the same outcome [9]. When Targets view their clone's interaction with the Interactors, they are observing a model highly similar to themselves and thus are more likely to have it influence their behavior in future interactions. In section 4.2.1, we saw how Targets express that they might potentially learn from their clone's behavior, akin to how people learn from observing others in social interactions.

Section 4.2.2, on the other hand, highlights how clones could also condense one's identity into a single dimension, removing its multilayered characteristic. Since they are trained on the actual conversation data of the Target, they are most likely to resemble the Target's enacted identity. Even when the clone is working as intended, it may still clash with the Target's other identities (e.g., personal, relational), causing emotional tensions from the resulting identity gap. This potential for clones to cause conflict within our identity may be difficult to overcome, as the clones will need to both capture every aspect of the Target's multi-layered identity, while also having the ability to apply that information to the appropriate context in every social interaction, i.e. be a perfect replica of the Target.

5.1.3 Effects of Clones on Relationship Development and Management. Although we cannot verify the long term impact of using clones on relationships, we can combine our findings with existing theories to speculate on their effects. Similar to how social media clones affect our identity, their potential impact on our relationships includes both positives and drawbacks. A common value that our clones concepts provide to relationships is an increase in social interactions for Interactors, which has been shown to benefit relationship formation [100]. This increase can be in the form of expanding the Target's social network such as in *Personalized Reachout*, or maintaining their existing relationships like in *Clone Housekeeping*. From a relational dialectics perspective, clones help address the tension of connectedness and autonomy, as Targets do not have to commit to the time consuming process of managing their relationships while still gaining the benefits of performing such tasks. From a social exchange perspective, clones reduce the cost for the Target to maintain a relationship while the benefit remains the same. Both these factors combined can incentivize Targets to keep relationships that they otherwise would not see as worthy of maintaining, and overtime increase the amount of professional and acquaintance level relationships across social networks.

For closer relationships, this perceived lack of commitment can be a detriment to long-term relationship development. Equity theory explains that people are most comfortable in a balanced and fair relationship [2]. As seen from section 4.1.1, many Interactors would be dissatisfied with the Targets' use of clones as they perceive clone use as a lack of effort in the relationship. This indicates that prolonged use of clones under these conditions may not contribute to relationship development, and could even harm relationships where a lot of effort and time investment is expected. Since Targets are not actually engaging in these interactions, it may also take away opportunities to develop their communication skills after prolonged use, a concern for some participants in our study. If used in moderation, clones may prove as a promising tool for Targets to develop and maintain new or distant relationships, with their utility decreasing as the relationship grows closer and the demand for more time and effort from the Target increases.

5.2 Challenges to Adopting Clones in Social Media

5.2.1 Differing priorities between Target and Interactor. By design Targets should be the owners of their clone in order to protect their personality rights. This is the right for an individual to control the use of their identity, including their behavioral mannerisms and likeness [72]. However, in all of the concepts, the Interactors are the ones that actually engage with the clones regularly. Clones therefore need both user types to function, but the needs of these users are often in direct contradiction to each other. Prioritizing the needs of one side may decrease the clone's attractiveness for the other side. This dichotomy between how Targets and Interactors engage with clones makes creating a well balanced clone accepted by both parties a difficult task.

Our findings indicate that Targets may view the clone as a way to reduce effort and stress as presented in sections 4.1.1 and 4.1.2. The most prominent concerns voiced by Targets were the threat to their identity (section 4.2.1), privacy (section 4.1.3), and online reputation (section 4.1.2, 4.2.2). In this regard, Targets value the effectiveness and control of their clone in order to maximize efficiency and minimize risks. Interactors on the other hand suggested they viewed the clone as a substitute for the Target, thus valuing authenticity and accuracy as shown in 4.1.3 and 4.3.2. Their primary concern is a decrease in genuine connections (section 4.1.1, 4.1.2), and being misled by the clone about their interaction partner (section 4.3.2). While ideally all of these attributes would be accounted for in the design of clones, they can at times directly oppose each other. This requires users to pick whether they prefer the clone to benefit them as Targets, or as Interactors. One such example is deciding whether the clone should be a realistic representation of the Target, or an idealistic one. Majority of Targets preferred the clone to represent themselves only in a positive manner like in section 4.2.2, but when asked as Interactors, participants would rather see a more genuine reflection of the Target's true personality. Since users may be both a Target and an Interactor, there may not be an ideal clone design that satisfies both roles, making it more difficult for adoption. With that said, Taber et al. have found that social media adoption may be more dependent on social norms rather than the affordances offered by any social media [82], making it possible for clones to be widely adopted despite its lack of unanimous priority.

5.2.2 Clones as a threat to the value of social media. The concern that clones may replace emotional connections between humans has been raised both in previous studies [16, 55] and through our participants in 4.1.2. This concern is especially noteworthy in the context of social media, as seeking friends and social support is the primary motivation for using these platforms for many people [52, 67]. Clones challenge this core value of social media as they by nature remove a level of human to human interaction. Although clones can automate basic relationship formation and maintenance, participants did not hold interactions with clones to the same regard as authentic human interactions, aligning with past findings in human-like virtual influencers [6]. When Interactors engage with clones, they do not consider it as an act of nurturing their relationship with the Target due to the one sided nature of the interaction. Taking away opportunities for building deep and meaningful bonds can act as a deterrent for the adoption of social media clones.

This issue is worsened as generative AI becomes more prevalent on social media, authenticity will become increasingly sought after by social media users. For instance, newer apps like BeReal [84] have built their entire platform on emphasizing authenticity by making users share their lives at random, uncurated moments during the day. Haimson et al. described this desire for online authenticity to be paradoxical, as social media users feel constrained by fears of judgment, social expectations, and platform dynamics [27]. Poorly designed social media clones risk exacerbating this tension by layering additional inauthenticity onto already curated online identities, further deterring clone adoption as observed in 4.1.2. Social media companies will therefore need to carefully consider if and how clones are to be introduced into their services, as platforms that fail to support authentic self-presentation may quickly lose their user base.

5.2.3 The dangers of parasocial relationships and social engineering. Although not explicitly investigated in our study, many participants raised concerns about how social clones could be misused (4.1.3), particularly by fostering parasocial relationships. Past work has shown how AI's reciprocation can give users a false sense of mutuality with the Target [47, 59]. This blurring of boundaries risks creating asymmetric attachments in which interactors feel emotionally connected to the Target despite the Target's lack of involvement or awareness. This constructed emotional attachment may even lead to Interactrors becoming susceptible to adversarial social engineering, as research have shown users often struggle to find harmful intent in chatbots disguised through familiar social cues [92]. A malicious Target could feasibly fine-tune their clone to maximize emotional manipulation and gain social influence over their Interactors [85]. Overcoming this threat may go beyond the scope of social media companies and require a combination of technology, policy, and human training to overcome, as outlined by Schmitt and Flechais in their proposed countermeasures to AI-generated deception [76].

5.3 Design Considerations for Creating Successful Social Media Clones

5.3.1 Role of a clone: functionally independent and sentimentally dependent. The role of the clone refers to how the clone should function within the Target's social media. Kim et al. found 2 dimensions that reflect people's perception of AI roles: human involvement - how dependent an AI is on humans to function, and AI autonomy - the perceived sentience of the AI [51]. The degree in which these dimensions present themselves in a clone can determine the role that the clone plays. This role not only infers the clone's design, but can also influence user perceptions of them. Kim et al. revealed that people favored AI with both higher human involvement and AI autonomy. This aligns with sections 4.2.2 and 4.2.3 of our findings, which demonstrated people's desire to get involved with their clone's activities. With this in mind, a successful clone should be: 1) Sentimentally dependent: The clone should not create new sentiments but only serve to enhance existing sentiments of the Target, but also 2) Functionally independent: The Target should not have to tell their clone how to perform its tasks. Being sentimentally dependent ensures an adequate degree of human involvement, which will allow Targets to define the context in which the clone should operate in. Being functionality independent ensures the clone retains a high level of AI autonomy, enabling it to behave at will within the given context.

5.3.2 Clone use cases: task-oriented interactions vs. social interactions. Even when clones are solely enhancing interactions, the nature of the interaction also matters. Past studies have shown that people perceive functional AI to be more useful than social AI [50]. This is consistent with our findings as many Targets agreed that concepts that are functional in nature such as *Personalized Reachout* were more appealing than concepts focusing on social interaction like *Interactive Profile*. This suggests that clones may excel more in platforms that emphasize functional interactions. As Facebook have a focus on building and developing social connections, Target participants felt more reluctant about using clones on their close friends and family. Interactors also voiced their concerns of having to deal with clones on the platform. A similar sentiment was also voiced by our participants for X, as the platform includes a mix of social and transactional interactions. LinkedIn on the other hand is primarily used for expanding the users' professional network and seeking career opportunities. This lends itself naturally to the strengths of clones in automating and scaling basic interactions. The lower expectations for deep human connections on LinkedIn can also increase the acceptability of clone use, as some participants already assume a level of inauthenticity on the platform. However, the concern for reputational damage was particularly high for LinkedIn, as any clone breakdown not only affects the Targets' relationships, but may also damage their career prospects. Although functional AI is generally preferred over social AI, the nature of clones may blur that distinction as a functional concept for the Target may be viewed as a social one for the Interactor. Overall, different concepts may be better suited to specific platforms, based on how well the concept's value matches with the goal of the platform, and the expectations of its users.

5.3.3 Disclosure of clone use: balancing effectiveness and transparency. Similar to previous work on AI transparency [69], the disclosure of clone involvement has been a point of contention during the study. Interactors would almost always want to know when they are interacting with a clone, as not knowing would greatly increase the likelihood of impression transfer discussed in section 4.3.1. They responded most negatively with concepts such as *Undercover Rejection* where the clone actively hides its presence, but were more accepting of clone use when its existence is disclosed such as when they conversed with their Target's chatbot. This becomes tricky when these Interactors would also be Targets in a real system, which in some cases are less eager to disclose their use of clones since the revelation can negatively impact their impressions and relationship as described in section 4.1.1 and 4.3.1.

Most participants agreed that disclosure should be determined case by case, and feel that not knowing in certain situations is a worthy tradeoff for the effectiveness of the clone. Concepts like *Personalized Reachout* or *Undercover Rejections* depend largely on not revealing the clone's involvement, while concepts like *Interactive Profile* assumes that the Interactor knows they are talking to a clone. Designers should consider the unique dynamic of the clone concept they are creating and determine how they are best able to maximize the level of transparency while maintaining the effectiveness of their functionality. Beyond individual interactions, it is pertinent to also consider the impact of clone disclosure on the overall system, as past studies highlighted how the proliferation of these technologies can have unintended consequences in online interactions [41].

5.4 Limitations and Future Work

Our study focused specifically on text-based clones within social media as it allowed us to explore a diverse range of concepts within the modality. However, many other forms are possible with existing technology such as audio or visual clones, which may offer unique affordances and new impacts to social media that future work should investigate. Due to the exploratory nature of our study and the time constraint between study phases, we prioritized the speed of development over the clones' technical fidelity. Using GPT-4, we produced 6 minimally viable chatbots with varied believability based on the quality of training data provided and the distinctness of each Targets' mannerisms. Although this imperfection enabled us to examine how breakdowns occur and the participant reactions that followed, certain mismatches such as overly enthusiastic tones or generic responses (4.3.2), reflect known limitations of current large language models. This has the potential to inflate the degree of distrust observed during our study. As future research build on our work, higher fidelity clones may be important for determining whether similar patterns of distrust persists when clones more closely resembles their Targets.

Another limitation lies in the composition of our participant pool. Despite some speculative insights from the participants on acquaintance and coworker relationships (4.2.2, 4.3.3), we mostly focused on social media friendships as our target relationship type. All participants fell within the 19–34 age range and were predominantly Asian. These factors potentially limits the generalizability of our findings to older populations or cultures with different values around identity, privacy, and AI adoption. While the uneven distribution of AI expertise among participants might reflect real-world usage gaps, it could skew the findings, especially the strong concerns around distrust, as "Beginner" users often hold higher initial skepticism. Future work should expand on each of the aforementioned avenues, targeting unexplored relationship dynamics, and extending the ideas from this paper to different cultural and technological backgrounds to gain a more holistic understanding of the impact of clones in social media.

6 Conclusion

Our study leverages the communication theory of identity and past work on AI-MC to explore the value and risks social media clones may pose to their users. This was achieved using a design workbook featuring eight social media clone concepts. From semi structured interviews with 32 social media users, we discovered that while these clones may enhance the social media experience by providing convenience and utility, they can also pose a risk to the agency and identity of their users. These findings build on existing literature in AI clones to provide more specific insights into their role in the social media domain. We expanded on these findings by discussing how clones can affect users in the context of agency, identity, and impression management, and the unique challenges in driving clone adoption in social media. We also offered design considerations regarding the role, function, and disclosure of social media clones for designers and platform owners. We are witnessing the rise of clones on social media as companies continue to experiment with the promises of generative AI. Although the long-term effects of these clones have not been uncovered, approaching their creation and integration with careful consideration and intent will be critical in ensuring they become a force for good within the ever evolving social media landscape.

Acknowledgments

This work was supported by the Institute of Information & Communications Technology Planning & Evaluation (IITP) grant funded by the Korea government (MSIT) (No. RS-2025-02303220, Development of a system for evaluating and validating the UI/UX of digital services for underprivileged groups).

This research was also supported by the Korea Institute of Science and Technology (KIST) institutional program (26E0062). We sincerely appreciate their support, which made this work possible.

We would like to thank all the participants that contributed to this study, and the members of SOCIUS lab and MUX lab at UBC for their continuous support and feedback.

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A Prompt for Creating AI Clone Chatbots

You are [Target]. Follow the talking style of [Target] in [conversation]. Follow [rules] in your responses.
[rules] = Keep answers as short as possible to maintain a conversational tone, and match your word count to the average word count of [Target]'s response in [conversation]. Introduce and refer to yourself as [Target] only when asked.
[conversation] = /// *conversation data provided by Target* ///

B Design Workbook Concept Tables

The tables used for categorizing clone concepts. B.1 contains innate attributes of the clone, while B.2 contains the behavior of the clone and the value that each concept provides.

Workbook Concept	Social Media Element	Clone Requirement	Disclosure of Clone Use	Optimal Relationship
1. Interactor Profile	Profile/ Message	High	Disclosed	Acquaintances/ Strangers
2. Cross-media Posting	Stream	Medium	Disclosed	Friends
3. Clone Housekeeping	Stream/ Network	Medium	Not Disclosed	Close Friends/ Family
4. Personalized Reachout	Network/ Message	High	Not Disclosed	Acquaintances/ Strangers
5. Undercover Rejections	Message	Medium	Not Disclosed	Acquaintances/ Strangers
6. Post-completion for Trending Topics	Stream	Low	Disclosed	Friends
7. Mood Modifer	Message	Medium	Not Disclosed	Friends
8. Group-convo Simulation	Message	High	Disclosed	Friends

Table B1. Design Workbook Concepts Attributes

Workbook Concept	AI Autonomy	Clone/Interactor Engagement	Degree of Interaction	Target Value	Interactor Value
1. Interactor Profile	High	1 to 1	Conversation	Make Friends (Bridging Capital)	Gain Information (Information Capital)
2. Cross-media Posting	Medium	1 to Many	Single Post	Content Creation	Gain Information (Information Capital)
3. Clone Housekeeping	High	1 to 1	Non Verbal	Content Creation	Social Support (Bonding Capital)
4. Personalized Reachout	Low	1 to 1	Single Post	Make Friends (Bridging Capital)	Make Friends (Bridging Capital)
5. Undercover Rejections	Medium	1 to 1	Single Post	Content Creation	Social Support (Bonding Capital)
6. Post-completion for Trending Topics	Low	1 to Many	Single Post	Content Creation	Entertainment
7. Mood Modifer	Medium	1 to 1	Conversation	Social Support (Bonding Capital)	Social Support (Bonding Capital)
8. Group-convo Simulation	Medium	Many to 1	Conversation	Make Friends (Bridging Capital)	Gain Information (Information Capital)

Table B2. Design Workbook Concepts Behaviors and Value

C Interview Questions

Phase 1 Target Interview Questions

(1) Now that you've seen all the concepts, what are your general thoughts on the idea of AI clones in social media?
(2) Would you consider using AI clones for your own social media?
  (a) If so, how often would you see yourself using it?
(3) In what ways can you see the clone enhancing your social experience?
(4) What are your major concerns of using such a technology?
(5) Was there a concept that really made a positive impression on you?
(6) What about one that you were concerned about or didn't like?
(7) What is your ideal level of transparency?
(8) What is the minimum level of transparency for you to still use it?
(9) Who do you think should be responsible for disclosing AI clone use?
(10) What type of things do you think could go wrong?

(11) How would you react if something does go wrong?
(12) When something goes wrong, whose responsibility is it? Who should resolve it?
(13) Do you think the clone can influence your behavior?
(14) If you had your own clone, do you think you would behave more like how your clone behaves?
  (a) Why or why not?
(15) What kind of assumptions would you make about someone using clones?
(16) Would this depend on your prior impression of them?
(17) Do you think seeing the clone conversation of people you follow will affect your perception of them?
(18) Would you trust your clone to engage in these basic interactions?
(19) How would you react if someone's clone said something offensive or rude to you?
(20) What impacts do you think having AI clones could have on you personally, and also on the general public as a whole?

Phase 2 Interactor Interview Questions

(1) How did you feel interacting with a clone of [name]?
(2) What was your overall impression with the clones?
(3) What aspects of the clone are the most promising?
(4) What are some risks that the clone might have?
(5) Would you still use the clone despite these risks?
(6) How would you react and resolve the following breakdowns?
  (a) Mismatch between clone behavior and target
  (b) Clone providing incorrect information
  (c) Finding out that in interaction with the following person was with a clone:
    (i) Acquaintance
    (ii) Close friend
(7) From the following tradeoffs, which side do you value more and why?
  (a) Manual control vs. AI autonomy
  (b) Realistic representation vs. Ideal representation
  (c) Data privacy vs. Clone accuracy
  (d) Transparency vs. Clone effectiveness
(8) Which concepts are more acceptable to you?
(9) Which concepts are you more open to disclosure?
(10) What type of relationship do you think the clones are best suited for?
(11) what type of relationships do you think it is acceptable to use clones in?
(12) What kind of assumptions would you make about someone using clones?
(13) Do you think in general your impression of someone would change based on how their clone behaves?
(14) Do you value the AI interaction in of itself?
(15) What impacts do you think having AI clones could have on you personally, and also on the general public as a whole? (positive/negative)

Phase 3 Target Interview Questions

(1) What was your overall impression with seeing your friends interact with your clone?
(2) How did you feel about the clone providing incorrect information to your friends?
(3) After seeing this conversation, do you feel like you would want to continue with talking to them with the same level of energy and friendliness?
(4) How would you feel if an acquaintance or stranger is able to talk to your clone and become closer to you without necessarily needing any reciprocation on your end?

(5) Where do you see the clones being the most useful for each of the social media platforms?
(6) In terms of the concepts, which ones are more acceptable to you?
    (a) What makes them more acceptable, what makes the others less acceptable?
(7) Which concepts does disclosure matter the most for you and why?
(8) What type of relationship do you think the clones are best suited for clones?
(9) What role do you think AI clones should play in social media if any?
(10) What are some long term impacts that AI Clones may have online?

Received May 2025; revised November 2025; accepted December 2025